DOUBLE ISSUE

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PERSON *of the* YEAR

TIME

GRETA THUNBERG

THE POWER OF YOUTH

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Greta Thunberg: TIME's Person of the Year 2019

Edward Felsenthal is the Executive Chairman and former Editor-in-Chief of TIME.

It began with a story line familiar to every parent of every generation in every corner of the globe: an indignant teenager and a sudden burst of rebellion. It became one of the most unlikely and surely one of the swiftest ascents to global influence in history. Over the course of little more than a year, a 16-year-old from Stockholm went from a solitary protest on the cobblestones outside her country's Parliament to leading a worldwide youth movement; from a schoolkid conjugating verbs in French class to meeting with the Secretary-General of the United Nations and receiving audiences with Presidents and the Pope; from a solo demonstrator with a hand-painted slogan (Skolstrejk för Klimatet) to inspiring millions of people across more than 150 countries to take to the streets on behalf of the planet we share.

Meaningful change rarely happens without the galvanizing force of influential individuals, and in 2019, the earth's existential crisis found one in Greta Thunberg…*Read the full story here.*

Greta Thunberg: TIME's Person of the Year 2019
Lizzo: TIME's Entertainer of the Year 2019
Disney CEO Bob Iger: TIME's Businessperson of the Year 2019
U.S. Women's Soccer Team: TIME's Athlete of the Year 2019
Public Servants: TIME's Guardians of the Year 2019

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The Story Behind TIME’s 2019 Person of the Year Cover

Karl Vick is an editor at large at TIME. He has also served as TIME's Jerusalem bureau chief. He has reported from 60 countries and in 2001 was a finalist for the Pulitzer Prize for Public Service for coverage of the spread of AIDS in Africa.

After returning to Europe by sailboat, Greta Thunberg greeted the throngs of press and young climate activists who trail her everywhere. She rested for a day, then returned to the sea to be photographed for TIME’s Person of the Year cover.

The image was taken by Evgenia Arbugaeva, who grew up in the Russian Arctic, and makes photos of remote, quiet and unlikely beauty. “When TIME asked me to photograph Greta, I was thinking how can I make a portrait that combines gentleness and at the same time courage. How do I capture the intense, focused gaze inwards

as well as outwards, which I feel is characteristic of Greta," she says. "It was not an easy task."

Arbugaeva wanted a photograph that captured the spirit of the young activist. She started by creating a mood board with references from Botticelli, Monet, Norse mythology, tarot cards, and Romantic period art.

She arrived in Portugal while Thunberg was still at sea and began scouting greater Lisbon for a location. "One day I saw a quiet winter beach with almost no people besides some fishermen," Arbugaeva says. "I had to consider privacy because the crowd surrounds Greta everywhere she goes. "I thought it was perfect."

The photo shoot would come in the thick of TIME's reporting. Before setting off from Hampton, Va., three weeks earlier, Thunberg was interviewed by national correspondent Charlotte Alter and climate correspondent Justin Worland aboard the catamaran *La Vagabonde*. In Lisbon, the teen met up with London-based correspondent Suyin Haynes, who had spent five days with Thunberg in April—at home, school, and on a 1,200 mile train journey—for an earlier profile published as part of TIME's May 27, 2019, "Next Generation Leaders" issue.

Thunberg arrived at the beach in a Tesla rented to bring her to the shoot. The sun was going down. "As she stood for a photograph, the sky colored golden pink creating beautiful light, ocean tide was

rising and waves were raging around her," Evgenia recalls. "Greta stood tall and strong without moving, just a few strands of her hair fluttering in a gentle breeze. She looked straight ahead into the ocean she just crossed. At this moment it felt as if all nature elements and forces aligned to create the magic—the most treasured gift for a photographer."

It may have been the last moment of peace the activist would have on the trip. The next day, she boarded a night train to Madrid, accompanied by Arbugaeva, Haynes and the media horde that would track her every step in the Spanish capital, where tens of thousands demonstrated outside the U.N. climate conference.

"From then on, crowds of journalists and security guards are constantly around Greta," says Arbugaeva, who graduated from the International Center of Photography in New York in 2009. "It was the first time I saw something like this, a real insane hysteria of people trying to get to her…But Greta seemed to handle it very well. I could see that she is on her mission."

This article is part of TIME's 2019 Person of the Year package. Read more from the issue and sign up for the Inside TIME newsletter to be the first to see our cover every week.

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Behind the Scenes of TIME's 2019 Person of the Year Issue

Edward Felsenthal is the Executive Chairman and former Editor-in-Chief of TIME.

Person of the Year started on a whim. At the end of 1927, the editors realized they had made it through the year without putting the 25-year-old aviator Charles Lindbergh on the cover to commemorate his historic solo flight that May across the Atlantic. The solution was to make him "Man of the Year," launching what has become one of the most enduring franchises in journalism. Lindbergh was not only the first but until now also the youngest individual to be named TIME Person of the Year.

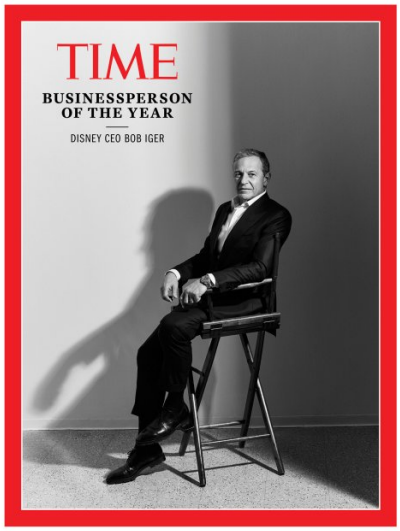
This year we name 16-year-old Greta Thunberg, who—via seemingly every mode of transportation except Lindbergh's—journeyed around the globe while leading a movement to protect it. Of course, the power of youth is hardly a new theme: in 1966,

TIME chose an entire generation, people under 25, as Person of the Year. “In the closing third of the 20th century, that generation looms larger than all the exponential promises of science or technology: it will soon be the majority in charge,” the editors wrote.

For our team, a joy of working on Person of the Year is the opportunity to look at the year through the prism of the people who shaped it. The formal process begins in early fall with a meeting where staff from all over the world make recommendations. We then launch numerous projects that could become the choice, led by teams of reporters and editors who themselves don’t know the choice until the end.

TIME has been on our own journey this year, setting up as an independent company with supportive new owners, Marc and Lynne Benioff; adding new franchises and events; growing our team; and deepening the ambition of our coverage.

We are also expanding Person of the Year to reflect the full range of subjects that TIME covers. For the first time, we're choosing the most influential person in a range of fields: Bob Iger, the meticulous CEO who is rewriting Disney's story with blockbuster deals, is our Businessperson of the Year. The U.S. women's soccer team, who inspired millions with their play on the field and their persistence off of it, is the 2019 Athlete of the Year. And our Entertainer of the Year is the irrepressible performer Lizzo, nominated for eight Grammys this year, whose message of positivity captured the culture.



There is one other category this year that is special to us at TIME. Last year for Person of the Year, we chose “The Guardians,” four journalists and one news organization who took great risks in pursuit of greater truths, standing up for free expression and democratic values. This year, we are recognizing a different group of Guardians, who took to the stand and risked their careers in the defense of the rule of law. That project, led by TIME’s Massimo Calabresi and Vera Bergengruen in Washington and Simon Shuster reporting from Kyiv, provides one of the most detailed accounts to date of the nonpartisan public servants who exposed the evidence that prompted the impeachment of a President.

Our reporting on Greta Thunberg this year actually kicked off well before we had begun to think about Person of the Year, when Suyin

Haynes journeyed with her over 1,200 miles by train for a profile in our Next Generation Leaders series. For this project, Suyin rode with Thunberg again as she headed to the Madrid conference on climate change. “Compared to when I traveled with her across Europe in the spring,” says Suyin, it was “a complete frenzy.” The resulting story, written by Suyin, Justin Worland and Charlotte Alter and edited by Haley Sweetland Edwards, is a remarkable portrait of what influence looks like in 2019.

“Despite the dire urgency of her message, there is optimism at the heart of this year’s choice,” says executive editor Ben Goldberger, who oversees Person of the Year. “To a generation let down by traditional power structures, Thunberg’s selection shows that you don’t need to be part of them to shape history.”

Perhaps it’s fitting that in his final years, Lindbergh became an environmentalist. “If I had to choose,” he said, “I would rather have birds than airplanes.”

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Greta Thunberg Is the Youngest TIME Person of the Year Ever. Here's How She Made History

Lily Rothman is managing editor at TIME. She was also the founding editor of TIME's history section.

With her selection in 2019, 16-year-old climate activist Greta Thunberg becomes the youngest individual ever to be named TIME's Person of the Year.

While the franchise has a long record of recognizing the power of young people, the editors have never before selected a teenager. Before 2019, the previous individual to hold the record for youngest Person of the Year was the first Person of the Year in TIME's history: 25-year-old Charles Lindbergh, selected as most influential man of 1927.

Lindbergh's age was, to many, inseparable from his place in the world. Though some of his admirers suggested that his feats of aviation made him so special that he ought not to risk his life with further flights, others believed that he could not stop as "heroes age swiftly when seated at office desks."

Some conceptual Person of the Year selections such as “You” (2006) and “The Protester” (2011) could include people who’d beat Lindbergh for the title of “youngest,” and perhaps the best illustration of the influence of youth can be seen in the Person of the Year selection for 1966: The Inheritor, the generation of Americans who were then 25 and under.

Read more: What It Means When TIME’s Person of the Year Is a Group

In the mid-1960s, young people represented an unusually large share of the population, and that generation’s impact was growing. “If the statistics imply change, the credentials of the younger generation guarantee it,” the story noted. “Never have the young been so assertive or so articulate, so well educated or so worldly. Predictably, they are a highly independent breed, and—to adult eyes—their independence has made them highly unpredictable. This is not just a new generation, but a new kind of generation.”

In the case of 1966, experts attributed this phenomenon to a confidence born of affluence and comfort, and of having grown up in a time of peace, even as the Vietnam War waited around the corner for many of them. The young Baby Boomers, the editors believed, were given a largely glowing world to inherit, and they

were sick of waiting to do so. That knowledge gave them the ability to speak boldly.

What they said was this: Our elders have sold us out. The system isn't working. The time to act is now. The world is changing faster than ever, and the young are the ones who see what's happening.

More than half a century later, many of the same themes have returned in the selection of Greta Thunberg as 2019's Person of the Year—if for a different reason. Due to the actions of prior generations, the Earth Thunberg's generation will inherit (a planet that TIME warned was in trouble three decades ago, when the Endangered Earth was Person of the Year for 1988) is losing some of its promise.

Her message is one the Boomers would have recognized in the 1960s: Our elders have sold us out. The system isn't working. The time to act is now. Perhaps even more drastically than it did in 1966, the world is changing, and the young are the ones who see what's happening.

And in 2019, as millions of people across the planet joined her, history was made by the vision of one young person in particular.

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